

Citizen Kane, Orson Welles's first movie, is based on the press tycoon **William Randolph Hearst**, who bans all mention of the movie in his newspapers.

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1941

Ernst Lubitsch, a refugee from Germany, directs *To Be or Not to Be*, a movie that **lampoons the Nazis**, and is said by critics to be in poor taste.

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1942

Children of Paradise, a **lavish historical drama** directed by Marcel Carné, is filmed in German-occupied France.

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1944

Suspected communists, 10 Hollywood filmmakers are called before the Committee Investigating **Un-American Activities**, blacklisted by the studios, and later jailed.

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1947

1941

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Humphrey Bogart stars in *The Maltese Falcon*, the **archetypal film noir**, and (the following year) in *Casablanca*.

1943

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In Italy, *Ossessione*, an **early neorealist** movie by Luchino Visconti, runs afoul of Fascist government censors.

1946

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The Best Years of Our Lives, by William Wyler, reflects the difficulties of US servicemen **readjusting to civilian life** after World War II.

1948

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The Bicycle Thief by Vittorio De Sica is a neorealist **alternative to Hollywood**, with a powerful, simple story acted by ordinary people.

This monumental movie spectacular was proof of the studios' willingness to make movies ever larger in their quest for excitement. Kong joined a monster hall of fame. Universal Studios had already made the iconic horror movies *Frankenstein* and *Dracula* (both 1931), *The Mummy* (1932), and *The Invisible Man* (1933), all popular entertainments that also exhibited some brilliant filmmaking.

King Kong was big, but it didn't have a monopoly on scale. By 1939, audiences were being wowed by *The Wizard of Oz* (its yellow-brick road seen in saturated Technicolor) and roused by *Gone With the Wind*, an epic romance set against the historical backdrop of the American Civil War.

In Europe, however, another war was about to start. By the end of the 1930s the Nazis' brutal rule

had had a major impact on the industry. Scores of directors and actors, among them some of Europe's most talented, had defected to Hollywood.

A postwar edge

World War II gave the movies that came after it a new, abrasive edge. Even Britain's typically sweet-centered Ealing comedies acquired a darker tone when Alec Guinness played multiple roles in the murder story *Kind Hearts and Coronets* (1949). Darker still was writer Graham Greene's peerless web of intrigue and betrayal in postwar Vienna, *The Third Man* (1949).

In the US, crime drama evolved into a new genre—film noir. Its swirl of stylized shadow play borrowed heavily from the German Expressionists of the 1920s, its

femmes fatales and world-weary gumshoes becoming some of cinema's defining figures.

From Italy came a different kind of downbeat. In the Rome of 1948, director Vittorio De Sica used a cast of real people to tell a tale of everyday struggle called *The Bicycle Thief*. It was the type of movie that lit a fuse in all who saw it. But perhaps the most influential movie of the era had already been made. An ambitious portrait of a press baron, 1941's *Citizen Kane* goes in and out of favor with critics, but its impact was immense. Its cowriter, producer, director, and star, Orson Welles, was 25 when he made it. As it would be again in the next decade, movies had been reshaped by young people too much in love with its possibilities to be hampered by the past. ■